Shahbaz Khan Kamboh was appointed commander of the Mewar expedition to capture Rana Pratap, ‘he sent back both Bhagwant Das and Man Singh on the ground that as “they were zamindars there might be delay in inflicting retribution on that vain disturber [Pratap]”’. Though Man Singh would go on to have a long and glorious career as a Mughal commander, he would never be sent to campaign in Rajasthan again.

Rana Pratap would go on to evade successive Mughal efforts to capture him for more than twenty years. He would lose all his great strongholds over the next few years and would be reduced to living in the Aravalli hills, in the village of Chavand, sheltered by the Bhil tribesmen. By maintaining a ceaseless campaign of guerrilla warfare and ravaging Mughal territories, Rana Pratap managed to recover some of his Mewar lands though the fabled fort of Chittor was forever forfeit. The rana’s absolute refusal to come to terms with Akbar and envision peace with honour can appear baffling. After all, the rana would not have been interfered with in any way that would have affected his religion and honour for, as noted by historian A. L. Srivastava and quoted by Rima Hooja, ‘there was no danger to Hinduism or the Hindu way of life from Akbar, who respected religious beliefs and susceptibilities of all classes of people and more specifically those of his Rajput allies and vassals’. Nor would the rana’s land and people have suffered. On the contrary, while other Rajput kingdoms like Amer, Bikaner, and Jaisalmer had prospered through Mughal contact, evolving art and architecture in new and vibrant ways, Mewar stagnated, its fields ravaged and despoiled through decades of neglect following the rana’s scorched earth policy. Perhaps the rana’s actions were determined in his boyhood itself when, in the gloaming of a Rajasthani evening, as the lamps were lit and jackals howled in the distance, the Rajput families were told stories of their ancestors by the Charans—stories of impossible bravery and incandescent destinies, of purity of blood, and resistance at all costs. When those ancestors included the indomitable Rana Sangha and Lord Ram himself, as the Rajput genealogies were reconfigured to include mythical heroes, then the destinies of the boys were likely preordained. In the end, perhaps, it was about the very definition of the word honour—who wielded it and who claimed it.

In an epic poem, written by the Charan poet Durasa Adha called the *Gita Ranaji Pratapasimhaji Ro*, the poet praises the rana ‘for preserving the dharma of the earth and the dharma of ksatriyas… other rulers bowed their